



Figure 3: Firefox OS demo

that your app doesn't have any potential issues with your manifest syntax nor have any security problems.

Web APIs and Web Activities

A Web API is, essentially, a JavaScript interface that lets you take advantage of the device-specific features (sending SMSs, push notifications, etc). A Web Activity is a JavaScript interface that lets you delegate an activity to another app. Using these activities, you can take advantage of your phone hardware and inbuilt apps. Let's look at an example. Make the following changes to your *index.html* file. Also, download the latest version of jQuery and save it as a file *jquery.js* in your myapp folder.

```
<html>
<body>
  <div id="image-display"></div>
  <script src="jquery.js"></script>
  <script type="text/javascript">
    var pickImg = new MozActivity({ name: "pick", data: {
type: ["image/jpg", "image/jpeg", "img/png"] } });
    pickImg.onsuccess = function () {
      var blob = this.result.blob; var img = document.
createElement("img"); img.src = window.URL.
createObjectURL(blob);
      $("#image-display").append(img); }; pickImg.onerror =
function () {alert("Something went wrong!"); };
  </script>
</body>
</html>
```

The above code takes advantage of the in-built file picker activity. It lets a user select an image file stored on the device and displays it on the screen.

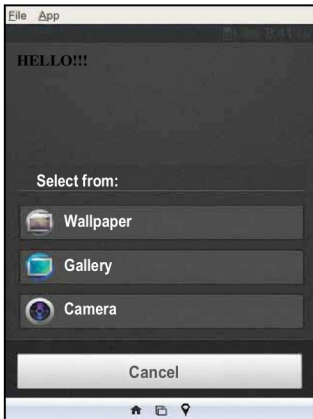


Figure 4: File chooser

Note: When using the Simulator, Firefox OS reads files from your default pictures directory on your operating system (Windows, Linux, etc) to mimic the SDcard; so if you get a message saying 'No files found', then populate that folder with images to select the files.

Building apps for the Firefox OS is easy, and quick to set up. The OS lets you develop Web apps with Web technologies while requiring minimal modifications. The MDN (<https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Web/Apps?redirectlocale=en-US&redirectslug=Apps>) website has most of the resources you will need to develop your apps. Information about HTML5, CSS and JavaScript can also be found on the MDN site, in case you need a reference while developing your apps. In conclusion, I think that Firefox OS' approach of using Web apps makes it a great alternative to Android, iOS and other mobile operating systems. With Firefox OS starting to gain momentum, this is the perfect time for you to start building apps on this platform. **END** 

By: Sahil Chelaramani

The author, a fourth year student at the Goa Engineering College (GEC), is an open source activist, who loves the Web, Python and Android.